

A Necessity That Gave Rise to a Successful Open Source Business

India has many emerging open source business models, but Liferay is unique. The company that came into existence because of the non-availability of an important product is making money without losing its roots in open source technology.

Diksha P Gupta from *Open Source For You* retraced the journey of the company with **Manish Gupta, general manager, Liferay India.**



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If you thought making money out of open source technology was a tough task, you would be wrong. Because all you need to have is a good concept, and a solid strategy to execute and commercialise it. Liferay began as one such concept that was then turned into a successful open source business.

Started by chief software architect Brian Chan to help the non-profit sector, Liferay was born in 2004. As they say, necessity is the mother of invention and Chan's case was no different. He was looking for a viable low-budget solution to create a website for his church. Chan couldn't find what he was looking for, so he thought of creating a solution for himself. And that precisely is the power that open source technology gives to the end user.

Liferay's flagship product named Liferay Portal is a free and open source enterprise Web platform with features to create both simple websites as well as complex Web platforms. Liferay Portal is written in Java, and is a JSR-286 compliant portal framework which includes a suite of

applications, including a Content Management System, blogs, instant messaging, message boards, etc.

The journey that began around 10 years back reached another level when the company spread its wings across India. Manish Gupta, general manager, Liferay India, offers the details about the company's journey. The very first question that comes to mind with a project like this is: why did someone choose to build it on open source? Gupta answers: "Unlike certain commercial open source companies today, Liferay Portal wasn't set up with the purpose of being a business but, instead, it evolved from the need to serve non-profit organisations. In fact, for the first four years (2000-2004), Liferay Portal was just an open source project. But in being an open source project, Liferay was able to reap the benefits of getting feedback and contributions from the community, something that it would have totally missed out on had it been a proprietary solution."

Open source: No more a niche technology

Open source has arrived but it is still sometimes considered a niche technology. Liferay has a different opinion on this. Gupta asserts, "Open source technology is not as niche as many think. In fact, it is now one of the de facto models to develop software. If we look at the software development landscape for the Web and the mobile, open source is everywhere. As a matter of fact, we at Liferay do not encounter any issues in proposing something that is totally based on open source. In our view, it is actually a mainstream movement now. The open source model, its underlying philosophy, and its wide reach and acceptability is what makes Liferay unique compared to a proprietary model."

Gupta goes on to elaborate, "Now customers are already well versed and have adapted to using open source technology. Most of the time customers know that they must adopt an open source route because they have seen others do it successfully, or it just makes plain sense to use it compared to costlier and closed source implementations. Thus, it is increasingly becoming easier to convince customers to adopt open source technology."

"In the case of Liferay, the discussion has moved from 'Whether or not to use open source technology,' to 'How to use and implement open source technology.' Customers now ask us or want to get convinced on how Liferay will integrate